

Identity, Culture, and Food: A Conclusion to the Course



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As we conclude the course, consider how the complex histories of both the food items that we eat and their integration into dishes, meals, and cuisines are deeply linked. Ingredients that we may associate strongly with one cuisine (such as tomatoes in Italian food, spicy peppers in Thai food) may be from another continent entirely, introduced only in the last few centuries. Yet other aspects of cuisine are millennia old and were invented multiple times in many cultures independently: fermentation of foods (especially for alcohol), methods to extend the shelf lives of stored foods, and reliance on different cultivated and wild foods for particular purposes, especially in times of scarcity. These common factors and the unique historical trajectories of different places and cultures around the world shaped the foods we see today, and our own sense of what is and is not appropriate to eat. Surely there is something you eat that another person, with a different background, might find unappealing (or worse)! And yet, it is not biological differences, but long-developed cultural sensitivities, that render some edible items food and others not food.

By considering the historical development of your food—both the evolutionary and historical trajectories of the food items and also the development of the methods for harvesting, preparing, storing, and cooking those foods—you can become more aware of not only what you like, but why you like it. Is the appeal of a food rooted in our deep evolutionary history, such as our preference for sweet? Or is it in tradition and membership in a culture associated with this food? Or is there a unique personal memory of the food that ties you to a dish? Take the time to consider these questions at a family meal, ask friends what different foods and dishes mean to them, and appreciate the long, complex history of our varied cuisines today.